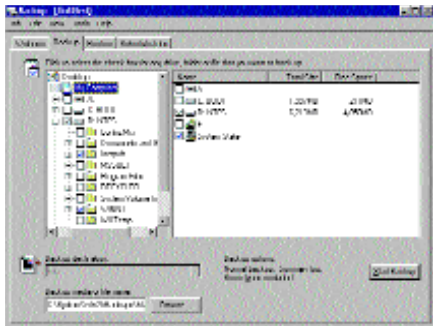


and System.ini files. Windows Me and XP use restore points, while Windows 2000 uses the Backup and Restore Wizard to save system settings. With restore points, you can take a snapshot of the entire system and save it to a restore point, which can later be used to roll back the system to that state. Thus, technically you would never require to freshly install Windows again. Backing up the System State on Windows 2000 will save all system settings to a file. As with registry backups, remember to set restore points or save system settings after every critical update or change. Unfortunately, restore points take up a lot of disk space, so it may not be possible to keep many of them.

If your Windows installation is set up for multiple users, simply exporting the



With the Backup and Restore Wizard, you can mirror an entire Windows 2000 installation

registry from the Registry Editor will not suffice. You should take a backup of the files that hold the registry, i.e. the System.dat and User.dat files in the Windows folder, and each User.dat file in the

Windows\Profile\<ProfileName> folder. To restore these files, copy them back to the correct locations while in DOS.

If you have a lot of fonts, copy them from the Windows\Fonts folder. Windows Explorer will only display the fonts that are installed on your machine; there are other font files here that are actually installed, you will not be able to see them. Thus, again it is best to copy these files to a different location using the Command Prompt. Your files on the Desktop are pretty straightforwardly copy them to a different location unless multiple users login to Windows. The same goes for your browser's bookmarks. If you have multiple users, you should remember to back up all files under the Windows\Profiles folder.

Understanding Program Structure

Most programs store settings in one or a combination of three possible ways: a file in the program's installation folder, a file in the Windows folder or in the Windows Registry. Again, typically most programs that use the registry store settings under two keys: HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\<Vendor Name>\<Program Name> and HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\<Vendor Name>\<Program Name>. Very few programs use other ways to store settings, such as a file in the root of the C drive or one in the System folder. Most programs also use INI files, though there are some programs that use different

extensions for their settings files. Thus, if you use Winamp, you will notice that it stores all its settings in a file named Winamp.ini, in the same folder where it is installed. WinZip, on the other hand, dumps it all in the Registry. As we have already seen, Windows and Office both use files as well as the Registry, and Internet Explorer and related tools (Outlook Express, MSN Messenger, etc) do not use any files and save everything in the Registry only. By understanding how different programs work, you can individually save settings for the ones you customise. However, if you are using software

such as Photoshop, you don't want to do with just saving the settings. You may be more bothered about the plugin settings (brush styles, shapes, etc) and any files you may have downloaded, saved or created. These are all located in individual folders within the Photoshop installation folder, unless you modified them. Plus, if you have been reading up on Photoshop tips, you may be storing fonts in the Photoshop folder—this way, Windows does not load the fonts every time you start Photoshop and though the fonts are available on the hard drive, the system runs a much faster load. Remember to copy the fonts to a

Precautions

Backup and restore operations are very easy, but be careful to use backups from a time when you were sure that the system was stable. Also, ensure that you are restoring settings for the same version of the application as when the backup was taken. This includes minor updates. For example, if you've backed up settings of Office 97 SR2, it is not advisable to restore them on an Office 97 installation without installing the Service Release first. Do not procrastinate in taking backups—every time your system successfully accepts an update and the PC works fine for a while, update all relevant backups. Finally, be very careful when working with the Registry.

Reinstalling Windows the Smart Way

All versions of Windows can be customised to be installed with predefined settings and without any dialog boxes popping up. Called Batch Setup or Unattended Install, this was originally designed for cloning installations across a large number of PCs, say, in an organisation, but is just as useful for reinstalling on your own PC. When you install Windows 98, it creates a file named Setuplog.txt in C:\. This itself can be used as a batch file. However, there are better ways of creating batch files on your own. On the Windows Installation CD itself, you will find a batch file creation tool in Tools\Reskit\Batch. Simply install and run this.

You can save all installation settings in a customised batch file, such as customising the desktop, licensing information, network properties, and optional components to install and save to a file. To use a batch file with the Windows 98 setup, simply type **setup batchname** at the DOS prompt.